

## The penalty that drained the Blasters

After losing two consecutive games, Kerala Blasters was desperate when it took on Hyderabad FC in Kochi. There was a glimmer of hope that the Blasters might return to winning ways. When the home side scored an early goal after a series of quick moves, the Blasters fans believed they might finally have a reason to celebrate after a long time.

But then came Hyderabad's equaliser, followed by a 70th-minute penalty that shattered the Blasters, resulting in their third straight loss.

It should not have been a penalty, as replays showed that the Blasters defender Hormipam did not handle the ball; however, the referee thought otherwise. Andrei Alba happily converted the penalty, scoring his second goal of the night to give Hyderabad a rather unexpected victory.

"I have to admit that the penalty drained us. That decision to give them a penalty in that moment was really, really hard for us. We were stressed after that and we lost the calmness with the ball, and made mistakes," said Blasters head coach Mikael Stahre.

"We lost control because of that penalty. I'm not that type who complains about referees... but you can't make a decision to give a penalty for that. Unfortunately, we lost the game by that. Of course, we have to look at ourselves in the mirror and perform better. The performance was obviously not good enough, but that penalty drained us."

**Stan Rayan**

## Elation, and then frustration

Under normal circumstances, Chennaiyin FC might have exercised a certain degree of caution in a home match against Mumbai City FC. After all, the latter is the defending ISL Cup champion.

But contrary to that, there was a palpable sense of swagger from Owen Coyle's Chennaiyin side, which seemed determined to take the game to Petr Kratky's Mumbai outfit.

Fresh from signing a contract that



would keep him at the club until 2026, Coyle urged his team to surge forward as soon as the referee blew the kick-off whistle. Mumbai's slow start to the season encouraged the home team to play with panache, buoyed by an enthusiastic crowd of about 8,000.

While the first half lacked goals, the entire contest came down to three minutes in the second half.

The crowd inside Nehru Stadium was brimming with anticipation. When Chennaiyin finally scored in the 60th minute — with captain Ryan Edwards heading home from a corner — the roof nearly came down. The celebrations were such that it felt as if nothing could go wrong.

But football, time and again, takes its fans on a rollercoaster of emotions, and this match was no exception. Just three minutes after the jubilant scenes of Edwards' goal, the crowd fell silent. Mumbai City equalised through Nathan Asher Rodrigues (right), ensuring the teams would share the points in a 1-1 draw.

"How did we not win this match? We had them, trust me," a Chennaiyin fan was overheard telling a friend while leaving the stadium. That question encapsulates the very essence of football.

**Aneesh Dey**

**Marked man:** Hyderabad's Andrei Alba (left) scored two goals, including a contentious penalty, handing Kerala Blasters its third straight loss.

